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Wi-Fi Repeaters

because it is occupied by a repeater but it still is really big. The NETGEAR WN3000RP is the smaller than the two and even has signal strength indicators which help you pick the best location for the extender. In a way, the WN3000RP makes it much easier for the average person with next-to-zero networking knowledge to set up a repeater. And then there's the RE200 which is a little big but it exhibits better signal gain so we're guessing that it houses a bigger PCB with a significant portion being used as antennae. The overall design of the 200RE is a lot more aesthetically appealing, so much that they've merged the WPS button into the design making it a little inconspicuous.

The D-Link DAP-1320 and Edimax Air units follow a very minimalist design in the sense that they have nothing but a status LED and WPS buttons. While this is a lot more appealing to a certain segment of the consumer base, there is the simple fact that troubleshooting these devices becomes a little difficult. Without an Ethernet port, you will have to resort to resetting the devices in certain situations and upgrading the firmware becomes a lot riskier over a wireless connection.

Lastly, we have the Edimax Mini and the Digisol DG-WR3001N which look exactly the same. The distinguishing features are the printed text along the body and the Digisol unit has a small mode switch on the side. No doubt, these were manufactured on the same factory line but the Digisol unit happens to be the better model because of the mode switch. Incorporating three modes will have cost a little extra and we'll see later on how they differ in terms of performance.

UI

The router UI is quite important for end-users, be it for the common folk or the enthusiasts. There's the fact that setting up networking devices is often a one-time thing and then you forget about it. So there appears to be little value in working on the UI but there's also the fact that the working on the UI isn't as difficult as working on the core hardware aspects. It's the little things that make a difference and a cumbersome UI adversely affects user experience.

Among the repeaters we tested, we found the NETGEAR WN3000RP, D-Link DAP-1320 and D-Link DAP-1620 to be the most user friendly. If you've used other devices from the same manufacturer, then the familiarity factor certainly helps with navigating through the UI. TP-Link with their RE200 and the TL-860RE are quite polished as well. It's only when you compare them with the aforementioned NETGEAR and D-Link products that the TP-Link UI seems to pale a little in comparison.

Edimax's UI could definitely use some reworking. While the Air and the Mini do certainly look pleasing, the UI is very stale and belongs in

the previous decade. It is functional in all aspects but that's about it. Digisol on the other hand definitely needs improve



Edimax EW7436RPN Air

the UI, we say this because certain features didn't even function properly, and that is the least you can expect from a UI. While upgrading the firmware to the latest version, the DG-WR3001N would not recognize the firmware binaries. A direct firmware upgrade service over the internet would have been considered as a workaround but this unit doesn't have that so you're stuck with the dysfunctional manual upgrade interface. And upgrades are often quite crucial, especially when switching platforms.

PERFORMANCE

There were a few surprising results when the benchmark scores were tabulated. We expected uplink and downlink speeds to be more or less the same with minor differences between products but it turns out that certain products did not perform as well as we'd assumed. Roughly half the devices had uplink speeds which were within the vicinity of 50 Mbps while the remaining half were lower than expected. TCP performance for the Edimax Air, Digisol DG-WR3001N and D-Link DAP-1620 were very close. The DAP-1620 had very less jitter in UDP performance compared to

the Edimax Air and the Digisol DG-WR3001N. In fact, if we are to disregard the moderate level of jitter that the Digisol unit exhibited, it pretty much performed way better than the rest. Even the signal strength was the highest we'd recorded across all devices.

The NETGEAR WN3000RP fell a little short of the rest with TCP performance and the jitter was off the charts, literally. It's one of the few things that should ever be off the charts with any device but we didn't notice any issues while streaming videos off the device which would indicate that the jitter levels were still too low to produce any noticeable affects.

Both TP-Link devices fell short in the TCP test with the RE200 scoring roughly



D-Link DAP-1620

half of what the other devices were outputting. But jitter levels were way lower. The TL-WA860RE didn't do well either and we tried fiddling with the antennae to see which configuration would help but things didn't work out for the device. The external antennae did help when the device was placed in Zone 3 as we noticed a good amount of time between connection drops. Zone 3 was the most difficult to penetrate and the TL-WA860RE was visible at all times.

Lastly, the Edimax Mini and D-Link DAP-1320 were at



TP-Link TL-WA860RE